

Giant panda

Ailuropoda melanoleuca

The giant panda—one of the most endangered and rarest mammals—is found only in six small, densely forested regions of central China. Estimates place the number of giant pandas remaining in the wild at 1,000–2,500. Once common in lowland areas, human activity has fragmented their habitat and pushed them up into the mountains.

The giant panda has the most distinctive coat of all bear species, but for decades its unique black and white markings, rounded face, and largely vegetarian diet led many scientists to conclude it was not a bear at all, until genetic testing settled the debate.

Slower than the average bear

The giant panda's diet continues to be a puzzle. It has the canine teeth and short digestive tract of a carnivore (meat-eater), but 99 percent of its food is bamboo, which, for pandas, is nutritionally poor. Carnivores, including giant pandas, lack special gut bacteria that would allow them to process grasses such as bamboo. This means that giant pandas get only about 20 percent of a meal's energy; if they ate meat, this would shoot up to 60–90 percent. It is not surprising, then, that the giant panda is slow-moving, spends most of the day eating up to

Giant pandas spend up to 16 hours a day eating bamboo

40lb (18kg) of bamboo, then rests for 8–12 hours. Its diet also prevents it from sleeping through the winter as it cannot put on enough fat to go without food for long. However, adults are truly bear-sized, and they are agile climbers and good swimmers as well.

Milk for two?

Giant pandas reach sexual maturity when they are between five and six years old. Although generally solitary, males and females spend two to four days together during the mating season from March to May. One or two tiny cubs are born around five months later, but the mother will abandon one cub if she cannot produce enough milk for both. A cub is fully dependent on its mother for the first few months, and may stay with her for up to three years.



◁ MOTHER AND CUB

Born hairless and blind, a newborn weighs just a few grams. New reserves and conservation work in China and zoos abroad are helping to boost the giant panda population.

△ PSEUDO-THUMB

An enlarged wrist bone in the giant panda's forepaw acts like a human thumb and helps it to manipulate bamboo stems.